biology, zoology, and botany. However, Odum believed passionately that studying plant and animal species in isolation could never lead to a full knowledge of the living world. He argued that it was more important to study the places and roles that the species held in their community, rather than simply finding out more about what they were. Odum's new approach to the subject—first set out in his 1953 book *The Fundamentals of Ecology*—revolutionized the purpose and influence of ecological research.



Salt marshes, such as these on the coast near Porthmadog, North Wales, form their own ecosystem, with the seawater and its nutrients providing a unique habitat for wildlife.